

THE SON CLAVE: RHYTHM THAT CONQUERED THE WORLD

A 5-note pattern found in every genre from salsa to metal — the mathematical foundation of groove

STEP 1: THE TRESILLO — BUILDING BLOCK

3 notes placed at maximum distance in 8 positions (positions 1, 4, 7)



1 0 0 1 0 0 1 0

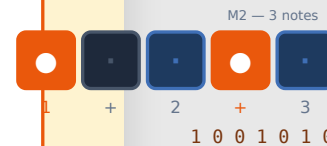
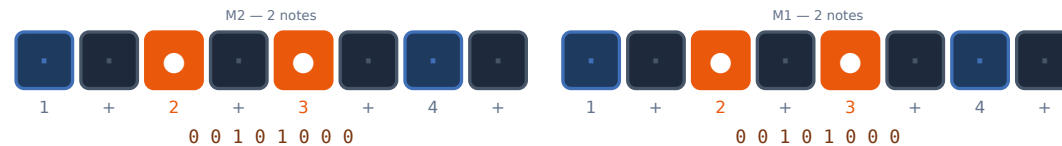
Found in: "Hound Dog" (Elvis Presley) · "Despacito" (Luis Fonsi) · "Shape of You" (Ed Sheeran) · virtually all reggaeton beats
The tresillo = one half of the son clave. It is the most evenly distributed 3-note pattern possible in 8 positions.

THE SON CLAVE — 5 NOTES OVER TWO MEASURES

3-2 SON CLAVE (3-SIDE FIRST)



2-3 SON CLAVE (2-SIDE FIRST)



3-2 = the 3-note measure comes FIRST · **2-3** = the 2-note measure comes FIRST
The direction is set by the kick drum or the first melodic motif — and stays **constant throughout the song**.

CLAVE VARIATIONS

Son Clave

M1: 1 0 0 1 0 1 0 0

Most common pattern. Foundation of salsa, pop, funk. Five notes maximally distributed across two measures.

Rumba Clave

M1: 1 0 0 1 0 0 1 0

Third note shifted one position later. Used in Michael Jackson's "Thriller." Slightly heavier, more grounded feel.

Bossa Nova Clave

Brazilian variant, 5 notes over 2 bars

Found in "Girl from Ipanema" (João Gilberto) and "Maple Leaf Rag" (Scott Joplin). Light, flowing feel.

HISTORY: THE RHYTHM THAT CONQUERED THE WORLD

First written record: Baghdad, 1258 AD — Safi al-Din's "Kitāb al-Adwār." The pattern was already established music theory in the Islamic world over 750 years ago.

African roots: The same pattern appears in Ghana's kpanlogo music and multiple West African percussion traditions — predating its written documentation by centuries.

Today: Found in ALL genres — pop, hip-hop, rock, country, EDM, jazz, classical, metal. It is **mathematically optimal**: the most even distribution of 5 notes across 16 positions. The listener's brain finds it naturally satisfying.